

FAITH CALLS
Devotees buying puja material outside the Shirdi Saibaba temple

MANDAR DEODHAR

an activist from nearby Kopargaon, claims that externed criminals from Mumbai and elsewhere have also been settling in the Kopargaon-Shirdi belt. Prostitution and drugs are now becoming an issue in the town, he alleges.

Indeed, locals complain that it is not unusual to see tractors and rickshaws full of labourers working in the nearby brick kilns, hawkers, beggars, even drunkards queueing up at the prasadalaya for free meals. Goraksha Gadilkar, CEO of the Shri Saibaba Sansthan Trust, says the coupon system for the meals has been changed after the gram sabha. Now, devotees get the coupon for use at the prasadalaya after the darshan or at the three 'bhakta nivas' facilities. Earlier, they could go to the prasadalaya directly. "After we changed the system, the numbers at the prasadalaya have gone down by around 4,000 daily," says Gadilkar. He, however, adds that they have no intention of making people pay for their meals.



"A crackdown on beggars is needed. Children are often forced to beg. **They harass devotees for money.** Criminals from other places have come to Shirdi and often bully locals"

—SACHIN TAMBE-PATIL
Former trustee, Shri Saibaba Sansthan Trust

be converted to a paid one. BJP leader and ex-Ahmednagar MP Sujay Vikhe-Patil is among those who have been vocal on the issue. He had first spoken out against the free meal scheme in January, courting controversy with his comment about "beggars from across Maharashtra flocking to Shirdi" because of it. "Considering the situation, the murders were destined to happen," he now says. "This has become a *bhojanalaya* (free eatery), which is a far cry from the 'prasadalaya' for devotees it was envisaged as," he says.

Shirdi resident Sudhakar Shinde says the system of polishwalas began around five decades ago when locals started acting as guides for devotees to make some extra money. Gradually, ruffians entered the trade and edged them out, he says. Sanjay Kale,

Officials say even if devotees turn up at the prasadalaya without a coupon, they are allowed in after verification. "The idea is to ensure that no genuine devotee goes hungry," they added. Sujay Vikhe-Patil says the fall in numbers proves his argument about shady elements flocking to the prasadalaya.

An official notes that it is difficult for them to charge money for meals as donations are given to ensure that food is provided free and for the religious merit that is said to accrue from '*annadaan*'. In 2023-24, devotees donated around Rs 99 crore for the purpose. The trust has around Rs 762 crore in its reserves for the scheme.

Shirdi is also battling another big problem, the sheer number of hotels and shops competing for the devotees' favour. Local hotel owner Dhananjay Shelke-Patil say the sector is saturated and says the competition has led to owners roping in the polishwalas and letting out their premises for "indecent activities" to stay afloat. "This has affected the reputation of even good hotels," he complains.

Officials say the Shirdi municipal area alone has some 600 hotels while the number in the larger precinct could be as high as 3,000. "We have a database of around 10,500 residential and commercial properties in our records, but no data on the occupants," says Satish Dighe, chief officer, Shirdi Municipal Council. The proposed survey will cover data points like whether the people are residents/tenants, living in Shirdi on a temporary/permanent basis, their place of origin and nature of work. "This will generate actionable data for the police and the district administration," adds Dighe. The census, the first such by a municipal body in Maharashtra, will begin in two months.

Meanwhile, the Shirdi police says the huge floating population poses significant challenges. Criminal cases being registered—including serious offences—have almost doubled in the past five years, up from 224 in 2021 to 430 in 2024. Ahilyanagar SP Rakesh Ola says preventive action has been taken against the polishwalas. The accused in the double murder case were arrested in a matter of hours using CCTV footage. "We are installing cameras to cover more areas in Shirdi," he says. The police have also been checking on externed criminals staying in Shirdi, a local crime branch division has been set up, and additional vehicles have been requisitioned for patrolling. The precautions should provide relief for now, but Shirdi and its residents will have to come up with a long-term plan that balances commerce and faith if it is to maintain its place as one of India's top spiritual destinations. ■